COLOSSIANS · STUDY 07 OF 12

Colossians 2:16–23

Run the Race Set Before You

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

Source: The Gospel Vault · used by permission
Editor: The Gospel Vault

① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

Scripture quotations taken from the (NASB®) New American Standard Bible®, Copyright © 1960, 1971, 1977, 1995 by The Lockman Foundation. Used by permission. All rights reserved. lockman.org

① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 2:16–23 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

2:16 *Therefore no one is to act as your judge in regard to food or drink or in respect to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath day—*

17 *things which are a mere shadow of what is to come; but the substance belongs to Christ.*

18 *Let no one keep defrauding you of your prize by delighting in self-abasement and the worship of the angels, taking his stand on visions he has seen, inflated without cause by his fleshly mind,*

19 *and not holding fast to the head, from whom the entire body, being supplied and held together by the joints and ligaments, grows with a growth which is from God.*

20 *If you have died with Christ to the elementary principles of the world, why, as if you were living in the world, do you submit yourself to decrees, such as,*

21 *"Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!"*

22 *(which all refer to things destined to perish with use)—in accordance with the commandments and teachings of men?*

23 *These are matters which have, to be sure, the appearance of wisdom in self-made religion and self-abasement and severe treatment of the body, but are of no value against fleshly indulgence.*

Scripture quotations taken from the (NASB®) New American Standard Bible®, Copyright © 1960, 1971, 1977, 1995 by The Lockman Foundation. Used by permission. All rights reserved. lockman.org

② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Don't Let Anyone Change the Rules

> *“things which are a mere shadow of what is to come; but the substance belongs to Christ”*
>
> *— Colossians 2:17 (NASB95)*

Imagine running a race and having someone step onto the track to tell you that you are breaking rules that were never in the rulebook. "You wore the wrong shoes. You ate the wrong breakfast. You did not observe the right holiday." And then the self-appointed referee declares that you do not deserve the prize.

That is what the false teachers were doing in Colossae. They judged believers by food laws and holy days, which were only shadows of Christ. They paraded a showy humility, spoke of angels and visions, and promised that "do not handle, do not taste, do not touch" would make people more spiritual. Paul says those rules have the appearance of wisdom but no power at all against the flesh.

The Christian life is a race, and its rules are written in the New Testament. We run with our eyes on Christ, who is the substance behind every shadow. We hold fast to Him, our Head, and the whole body grows with a growth that comes from God. Do not let anyone cheat you of your prize.

For reflection

1. Has anyone ever made you feel less spiritual because of a rule that is not in Scripture?
2. Have you ever judged another believer that way?
3. What would it look like this week to "hold fast to the Head" rather than to a list of rules?

Shadows have their place, but you are walking with the One who casts them.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Because Christ is the substance of which the Old Testament ceremonies were shadows, and because believers died with Christ to the world's elementary principles, believers must not let anyone judge them by religious rules or disqualify them from their reward through false humility, angel worship, and visions, for man-made asceticism looks wise but has no power against the flesh.

Outline

I. Don't Let Anyone Judge You by the Rules (2:16–17)
- A. The Areas of the Judging (2:16)
- B. The Error of the Judging (2:17)

II. Don't Let Anyone Disqualify You from Your Prize (2:18–19)
- A. Your Reward Is at Stake (2:18a)
- B. Their Alternative (2:18b–19)

III. Asceticism Cannot Produce True Spirituality (2:20–23)
- A. The Question (2:20–22)
- B. The Answer (2:23)

Introduction

Paul often uses athletic pictures for the Christian life (1 Cor. 9:24–27; Phil. 3:13–14; 2 Tim. 4:7–8). The Christian life is a race. Its rules are set forth in the New Testament, and the Old Testament ceremonial rules do not govern the believer's race. In this passage Paul gives two negative commands, both drawn from the language of judging and the athletic arena, and then asks a probing question about asceticism.

Note the word "therefore" (v.16). Because believers are complete in Christ (2:10), because the debt of the Law has been nailed to the cross (2:14), and because the hostile powers behind legalism have been disarmed (2:15), no one has the right to impose those rules again.

I. Don't Let Anyone Judge You by the Rules (2:16–17)

A. The Areas of the Judging (2:16)

"Therefore no one is to act as your judge in regard to food or drink or in respect to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath day." Paul lists five areas, all drawn from the Mosaic system.

1. Food

The Law carefully distinguished clean and unclean animals:

> *“Whatever divides a hoof, thus making split hoofs, and chews the cud, among the animals, that you may eat.”*
>
> — Leviticus 11:3 (NASB95)

But Jesus Himself "declared all foods clean" (Mark 7:19), a lesson Peter found extremely hard to learn (Acts 10:14–15; 11:8–9). False teachers have always loved food laws, and Paul says such teaching can come from "deceitful spirits and doctrines of demons":

> *“men who forbid marriage and advocate abstaining from foods which God has created to be gratefully shared in by those who believe and know the truth. For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with gratitude; for it is sanctified by means of the word of God and prayer.”*
>
> — 1 Timothy 4:3–5 (NASB95)

> *“for the kingdom of God is not eating and drinking, but righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.”*
>
> — Romans 14:17 (NASB95)

2. Drink

The Law said little about drink as such, though it had rules about vessels and about Nazirite vows. The false teachers may have added ascetic rules of their own.

Food and drink rules are still with us. Various religious groups prohibit certain foods or drinks, require seasons of fasting, or forbid pork, tea, or coffee. Believers are free to abstain for reasons of health or conscience, and they must not offend a weaker brother (Rom. 14). But no one may make such rules a measure of spirituality or acceptance with God.

3. Festival

Three times a year all Jewish men were to appear before the Lord: at the Feast of Unleavened Bread (Passover), the Feast of Weeks (Pentecost), and the Feast of Booths (Deut. 16:16; cf. Exod. 23:14–17; 34:18–23).

4. New moon

The new moon was marked by special offerings, "the burnt offering of the new moon and its grain offering" (Num. 29:6). Paul rebuked the Galatians for a similar return to the calendar: "You observe days and months and seasons and years" (Gal. 4:10).

5. Sabbath

The Sabbath was the fourth of the Ten Commandments. It is the only one of the ten not repeated as a command for the Church in the New Testament. This Colossian passage explicitly forbids anyone to judge believers for not keeping it. Groups that make Sabbath observance a test of faithfulness should consider this verse carefully. Believers gather for worship on the first day of the week, the day of resurrection (Acts 20:7; 1 Cor. 16:2), not as a new Sabbath law but in joyful freedom.

B. The Error of the Judging (2:17)

1. Those things are shadows

"Things which are a mere shadow of what is to come." A shadow (*skia*) is a mere outline of something real. It has a shape, but no substance. For instance, the Sabbath foreshadowed the rest believers have in Christ (Heb. 4:9–10), and the Passover pictured the sacrifice of Christ, "our Passover" (1 Cor. 5:7).

2. Christ is the substance

"But the substance belongs to Christ." The word for "substance" is *sōma*, "body." The physical things of Old Testament worship are the shadow; Christ and the realities of the New Covenant are the body that casts it (Heb. 10:1). Strangely, people like to grasp what seems visible, measurable, and manageable rather than the spiritual realities of the New Covenant. But now that Christ has come, why be occupied with shadows? It is like gazing at a photograph when the very person pictured is standing in the room.

II. Don't Let Anyone Disqualify You from Your Prize (2:18–19)

The second command also comes from the athletic arena: "Let no one keep defrauding you of your prize." The verb (*katabrabeuō*) is formed from *brabeus*, the umpire who awarded the prize. It means to rule against someone, to disqualify him. It is a present imperative with a negative, which can carry the idea "stop letting anyone do this."

A. Your Reward Is at Stake (2:18a)

The New Testament speaks clearly and often about rewards for believers, sometimes called crowns (1 Cor. 3:12–15; 9:25; 2 Tim. 4:8; James 1:12; 1 Pet. 5:4; Rev. 22:12). Jesus spoke of them again and again (Matt. 5:12; 6:1–6, 16–18; 10:42; 16:27). The prize here is not eternal life, which is a free gift (Rom. 6:23), but the reward a believer may win or lose by how he runs.

The picture is of a self-appointed referee who declares that you do not deserve a reward. Possibly the legalists were declaring that anyone who did not submit to their system was unworthy of a reward. The irony is that any believer who did succumb to their system would be the one in danger of forfeiting his reward, by turning from Christ to rules.

B. Their Alternative (2:18b–19)

1. False humility

"By delighting in self-abasement." The word is "humility" (*tapeinophrosynē*), but the context shows that it is false. They took delight in their humility; they knew they had it. And the minute you know you are humble, you are not. (Someone once joked about a book titled *Humility and How I Attained It*.) This was a showy, self-imposed lowliness, likely including fasting and harsh treatment of the body (v.23).

2. Worship of angels

"And the worship of the angels." Perhaps the false teachers thought it presumptuous to approach God directly, so they "humbly" approached angels instead. But Scripture invites every believer to come directly:

> *“Therefore let us draw near with confidence to the throne of grace, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need.”*
> — Hebrews 4:16 (NASB95)

And when the apostle John fell down before an angel, he was sharply corrected:

> *“Then I fell at his feet to worship him. But he said to me, “Do not do that; I am a fellow servant of yours and your brethren who hold the testimony of Jesus; worship God. For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy.””*
> — Revelation 19:10 (NASB95)

3. Visions

"Taking his stand on visions he has seen." The verb (*embateuō*) was used of entering a sacred place or of an initiate entering a mystery shrine. These teachers claimed authority from visionary experiences. Because those visions contradicted Scripture, they did not come from God. Claimed visions remain a foundation for a number of modern movements, and the test is always the same: does it agree with the written Word?

4. Pride

"Inflated without cause by his fleshly mind." In trying to show off his humility, the false teacher became proud. The verb (*physioō*) means to puff up like a bellows. The teachers probably boasted that they were guided by "the mind," by spiritual insight. Paul agrees, with a twist: yes, by a mind, but "the mind of the flesh."

5. Not holding fast to the Head

"And not holding fast to the head, from whom the entire body, being supplied and held together by the joints and ligaments, grows with a growth which is from God" (v.19). Here is the root problem. The false teacher had lost his grip on Christ. Life, nourishment, unity, and growth all flow from the Head. When a member lets go of the Head, all his religious activity cannot produce the growth that only God gives.

III. Asceticism Cannot Produce True Spirituality (2:20–23)

A. The Question (2:20–22)

1. The assumption

"If you have died with Christ to the elementary principles of the world." The "if" assumes the fact (a first class condition); we may read it "since." At the moment of justifying faith, Christ's death became our death. We died with Him, and the benefits of His death became ours immediately. In verse 12 Paul described this as being "buried with Him in baptism." Paul speaks of the believer's death with Christ in several relationships:

- Dead to sin (Rom. 6:2).

- Dead to self (2 Cor. 5:14–15).
- Dead to the Law (Rom. 7:4, 6).
- Dead to the world (Gal. 6:14).

Here the Colossians died "to the elementary principles of the world," a definite break with the world's system of religion, which lies under the power of the evil one (1 John 5:19) and is marked by "the lust of the flesh and the lust of the eyes and the boastful pride of life" (1 John 2:16).

2. The inquiry

"Why, as if you were living in the world, do you submit yourself to decrees?" The verb (*dogmatizesthe*) means to let yourself be "dogmatized," to allow life to become a round of rules again. The Mosaic Law is in the background, but Paul has in mind a system that merged pagan ideas with Mosaic elements. Nothing in the Law of Moses called for the arbitrary self-abasement and severe treatment of the body found here.

3. The prohibitions

"Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!" (v.21). These three pretty well eliminate any use at all. And the list keeps growing, as legalistic lists always do.

4. The explanation

"(Which all refer to things destined to perish with use) — in accordance with the commandments and teachings of men" (v.22). These rules concern perishable things. Jesus explained that food "does not go into his heart, but into his stomach, and is eliminated" (Mark 7:19). And they rest on human authority, the "commandments and teachings of men" (cf. Isa. 29:13; Mark 7:7).

B. The Answer (2:23)

1. These things appear to be wise

"These are matters which have, to be sure, the appearance of wisdom in self-made religion and self-abasement and severe treatment of the body." Many people like to be challenged to deny themselves: to wear certain clothes, eat or avoid certain foods, refuse certain pleasures, even inflict hardship on themselves. It looks like proof of devotion to the Lord. It appears to work.

2. They have no value against the flesh

"But are of no value against fleshly indulgence." Here is the verdict. Asceticism is worthless for curbing the flesh or producing true spirituality. Rules can change behavior on the surface for a while, but they cannot change the heart, and the flesh often grows proud of its own rule-keeping. Victory over the flesh comes another way, which Paul will explain in chapter 3: by setting our minds on Christ above and living out our new life in Him.

Conclusion

The errors Paul confronted in Colossae are still with us. We can summarize them as four counterfeit "higher" paths:

Gnosticism, "higher knowledge," which says Christ is not enough without a secret insight. **Legalism**, "higher practice," which says rule-keeping wins God's love. **Mysticism**, "higher contemplation," which looks to visions and mediators other than Christ. **Asceticism**, "higher retreat," which seeks merit through self-denial. Each looks wise. None has any power against the flesh. Only Christ, the Head and the substance, gives the growth that is from God. Hold fast to Him, and do not let anyone cheat you of your prize.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.16	**κρίνω** *act as judge*	**G2919** *krinō* Pres. Act. Imp. 3rd Sg.	**THAY:** to judge, pronounce an opinion, condemn. **Significance:** No one has the right to sit in judgment over believers on these matters.
v.16	**βρῶσις** *food*	**G1035** *brōsis* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** the act of eating, food. **Significance:** Food laws were shadows; Jesus declared all foods clean (Mark 7:19).
v.16	**νεομηνία** *new moon*	**G3561** *neomēnia* Gen. Fem. Sg.	**LXX:** the monthly new-moon observance (Num. 29:6). **Significance:** Calendar rites belong to the shadow, not the substance.
v.16	**σάββατον** *Sabbath*	**G4521** *sabbaton* Gen. Neut. Pl.	**VINE:** the seventh day of rest; plural form used of a single Sabbath. **Significance:** Believers may not be judged for not keeping the Sabbath.
v.17	**σκιά** *shadow*	**G4639** *skia* Nom. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** an outline, a shadow cast by an object (cf. Heb. 10:1). **Significance:** The ceremonies outlined Christ; they were never the reality.
v.17	**σῶμα** *substance*	**G4983** *sōma* Nom. Neut. Sg.	**ATR:** literally "body," the reality that casts the shadow. **Significance:** Christ is the body behind every shadow.
v.18	**καταβραβεύω** *defraud of prize*	**G2603** *katabrabeuō* Pres. Act. Imp. 3rd Sg.	**MRV:** from *brabeus*, the umpire; to decide against, disqualify. **Significance:** Legalists act as self-appointed referees; the issue is reward, not eternal life.
v.18	**ταπεινοφροσύνη** *self-abasement*	**G5012** *tapeinophrosynē* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** lowliness of mind; here a counterfeit, self-conscious humility. **Significance:** Humility that delights in itself is not humility at all.
v.18	**θρησκεία** *worship*	**G2356** *thrēskeia* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** religious worship, especially external ritual. **Significance:** Angel worship is forbidden (Rev. 19:10); believers approach God directly (Heb. 4:16).
v.18	**ἐμβατεύω** *taking his stand*	**G1687** *embateuō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**MRV:** used of entering a sacred precinct or of initiates in the mysteries. **Significance:** Authority claimed from visions rather than from Scripture.
v.18	**φυσιόω**	**G5448**	**STR:** to puff up, blow up, as with a bellows.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
	inflated	*physioō* Pres. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**Significance:** False humility breeds real pride.
v.20	**δογματίζω** *submit to decrees*	**G1379** *dogmatizō* Pres. Mid./Pass. Ind. 2nd Pl.	**ATR:** "Why do you let yourselves be dogmatized?" **Significance:** Believers should not let life become a round of rules again.
v.23	**ἐθελοθρησκία** *self-made religion*	**G1479** *ethelothrēskia* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** self-chosen worship. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** Religion invented by human will rather than revealed by God.
v.23	**πλησμονή** *indulgence*	**G4140** *plēsmonē* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** a filling up, satiety, gratification. **Significance:** Rules cannot stop the flesh from gratifying itself.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
Name the five areas of judging in verse 16.	Food, drink, festival, new moon, Sabbath.
What is the relation between shadow and substance?	OT ceremonies are the shadow; Christ is the body (*sōma*) that casts it.
What does "defraud you of your prize" picture?	An umpire disqualifying an athlete; the issue is reward, not eternal life.
Give the five marks of the false teacher in vv.18–19.	False humility, angel worship, visions, pride, not holding fast to the Head.
What is Paul's verdict on asceticism (v.23)?	It looks wise but has no value against fleshly indulgence.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Why can no one judge a believer regarding food, festivals, or the Sabbath?

> **Leader's answer:** Because these were shadows pointing to Christ, the substance, and because the Law's decrees were canceled and nailed to the cross (2:14). Believers in Christ are not under those ceremonial requirements.

2. What is the "prize" in verse 18, and how could a believer lose it?

> **Leader's answer:** It is the reward for faithful running, not eternal life, which is a free gift. A believer could forfeit reward by turning from Christ, the Head, to a system of rules, mysticism, and false humility.

3. Why is the worship of angels such a serious error, even if it looks humble?

> **Leader's answer:** It substitutes creatures for the Creator (1:16), denies the believer's direct access to God through Christ (Heb. 4:16), and is explicitly forbidden (Rev. 19:10). Its "humility" is really pride.

4. What does "not holding fast to the Head" (v.19) reveal about the root of the problem?

> **Leader's answer:** The false teacher had lost his grip on Christ. All the body's supply, unity, and growth come from the Head; cut off from Him, no amount of religious activity can produce growth from God.

5. If rules cannot stop the flesh, what can?

> **Leader's answer:** Paul answers in chapter 3: since believers died and rose with Christ, they must set their minds on things above and live out their new life in Him by faith and the Spirit's power, not by ascetic rules.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
2:16–17	Don't be judged by rules	Food, drink, festivals, new moons, and Sabbaths are shadows; Christ is the substance.
2:18–19	Don't be disqualified	False humility, angel worship, visions, and pride come from losing hold of the Head.
2:20–22	The question	Having died with Christ, why submit to "do not handle, taste, touch"?
2:23	The answer	Asceticism looks wise but has no value against the flesh.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Enjoy Your Freedom Without Judging Others

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:16; Romans 14:1–4

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I

No one may judge you by rules about food, drink, or holy days. But freedom cuts both ways: you also may not judge the brother who chooses to abstain or observe a day for the Lord, as long as he does not make it a requirement for others. Freedom in Christ is exercised in love.

Reflection: Do you tend more to judge others by rules, or to feel judged by them?

Practical step: Identify one extra-biblical rule you have used to measure spirituality and lay it down this week.

2. Run for the Prize

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:18; 1 Corinthians 9:24–27

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.A; cf. Hodges, Grace in Eclipse (FGR)

Eternal life is a free gift, but the New Testament also holds out rewards for faithful believers. Zane Hodges's Grace in Eclipse argued that when the truth of rewards is lost, believers lose a major biblical motive for faithful living. Run your race with your eyes on Christ, and do not let legalists or mystics cheat you of what He wants to give.

Reflection: Do you think about the Judgment Seat of Christ as a motivation for daily faithfulness?

Practical step: Read 1 Corinthians 3:10–15 this week and write down one way you want to build with "gold, silver, precious stones."

3. Hold Fast to the Head

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:19

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.B.5, and ④ Study Question 4

Growth that is from God comes only through connection to Christ. Rules, experiences, and spiritual techniques cannot replace time with Him in His Word and in prayer, and they cannot replace the joints and ligaments of the body, the fellowship of other believers.

Reflection: What has loosened your grip on Christ recently?

Practical step: Set aside fifteen unhurried minutes each day this week for Scripture and prayer, beginning with Colossians 1:15–20.

End of Study · Colossians 2:16–23